



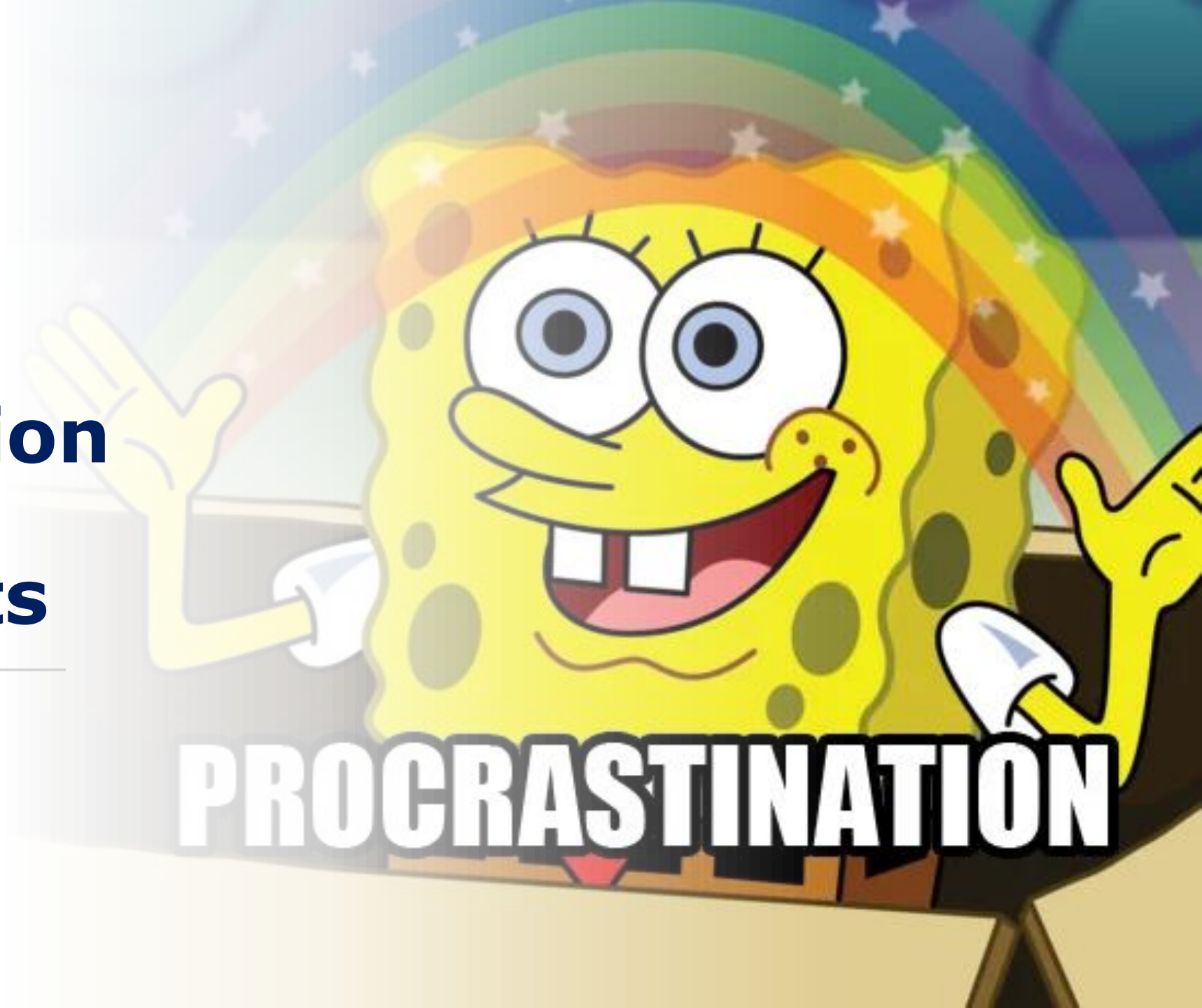
SFI Centre for Research Training
in Foundations of Data Science

Procrastination in Older Adults

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&

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Overview

- Background
- Finding data – Health and Retirement Study
- Building a model
- Results
- Conclusions



Procrastination – Misconceptions

~~Laziness~~

~~Lack of
discipline~~

~~Poor time
management~~

~~Only affects
work~~

~~Bad habit~~



Procrastination – Misconceptions

To procrastinate is to voluntarily delay an intended course of action despite expecting to be worse off for the delay

Voluntary

Typically, not involuntary, but rather a conscious decision

Intended course of action

Occurs when you have a specific task or goal in mind that you plan to undertake

Worse off for the delay

Anticipating that this delay will have negative consequences

Procrastination – Quick Statistics

Psychological Bulletin
2007, Vol. 133, No. 1, 65–94

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0033-2909/07/\$12.00 DOI: 10.1037/0033-2909.133.1.65

The Nature of Procrastination: A Meta-Analytic and Theoretical Review of Quintessential Self-Regulatory Failure

Piers Steel
University of Calgary

Procrastination is a prevalent and pernicious form of self-regulatory failure that is not entirely understood. Hence, the relevant conceptual, theoretical, and empirical work is reviewed, drawing upon correlational, experimental, and qualitative findings. A meta-analysis of procrastination's possible causes and effects, based on 691 correlations, reveals that neuroticism, rebelliousness, and sensation seeking show only a weak connection. Strong and consistent predictors of procrastination were task aversiveness, task delay, self-efficacy, and impulsiveness, as well as conscientiousness and its facets of self-control, distractibility, organization, and achievement motivation. These effects prove consistent with temporal motivation theory, an integrative hybrid of expectancy theory and hyperbolic discounting. Continued research into procrastination should not be delayed, especially because its prevalence appears to be growing.

Keywords: procrastination, irrational delay, pathological decision making, meta-analysis

Procrastination – Quick Statistics



Students

80 – 95% of students
report that they
procrastinate



Adults

15 – 20% of adults
consider themselves
procrastinators



Older Adults

?

Procrastination – Older Adults

Older adults face a range of **uncontrollable life factors**

Physical and cognitive decline

Loss of loved ones

Retirement

Loneliness

- Tasks can lose their purpose and significance for lonely individuals (Weiss, 1975)
- Furthermore, loneliness can negatively affect cognitive functioning and in turn, decision-making processes (Lara et al., 2019)

Depression

- Symptoms such as reduced pleasure in activities, low levels of energy, and difficulties concentrating are noted as common reasons for procrastination.
- While depression is less prevalent in older adults its effects and symptoms can still be profoundly detrimental.

Research Questions

- Does increasing age have an effect of levels of procrastination
- Does loneliness and/or depression have an indirect effect on procrastination tendencies among older adults



Procrastination – Data



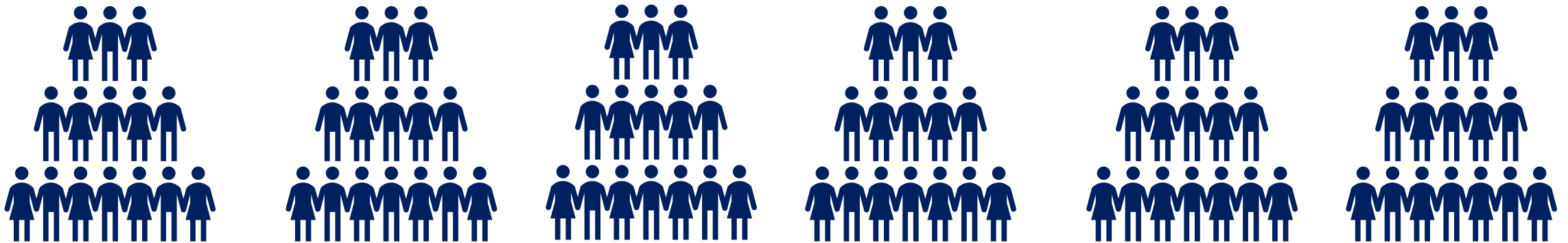
HRS

HEALTH AND RETIREMENT STUDY
A Longitudinal Study of Health, Retirement, and Aging
Sponsored by the National Institute on Aging



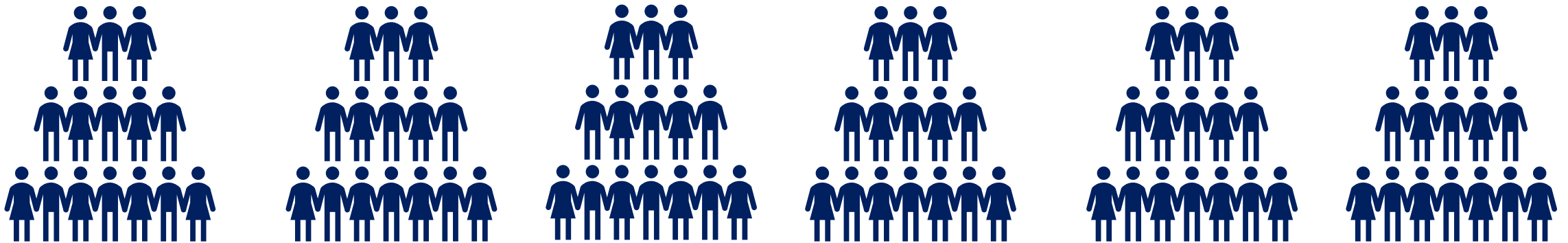
The Health and Retirement Study

- The HRS is a longitudinal panel study that surveys approximately 20,000 American adults (predominantly focuses on adults over the age of 50).
- Every 2 years detailed information pertaining to respondent's physical, cognitive, financial, employment, family, and psychosocial conditions is collected.



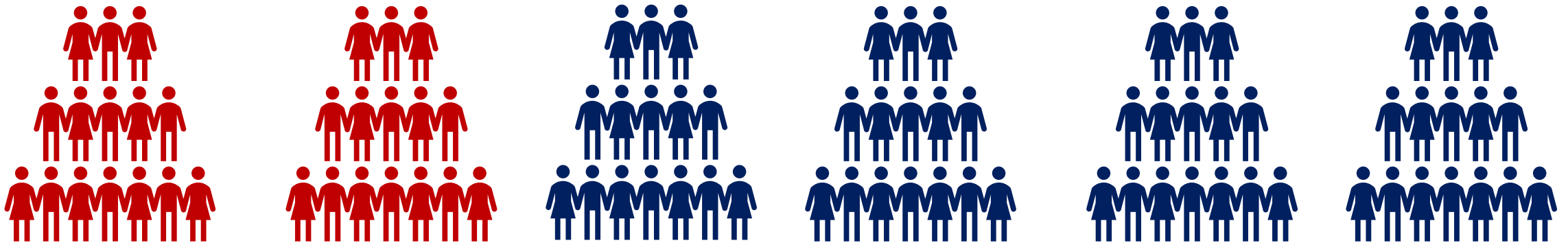
The Health and Retirement Study

- Each wave includes **experimental modules** that are administered at the end of the core interview.



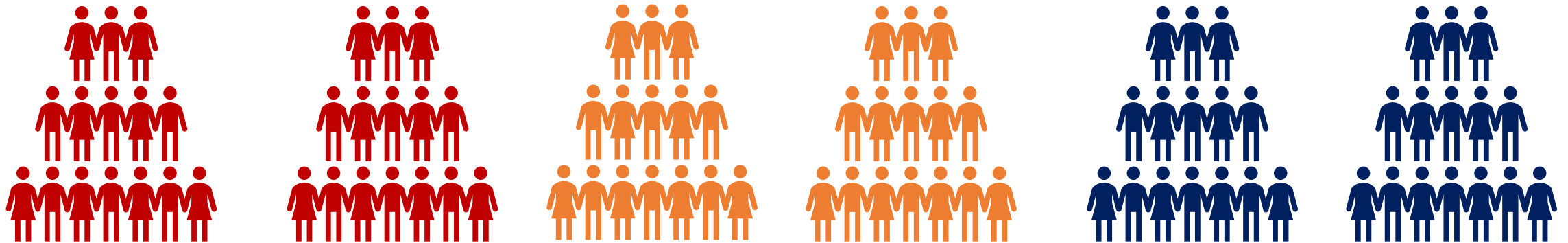
The Health and Retirement Study

- Each wave includes **experimental modules** that are administered at the end of the core interview.



The Health and Retirement Study

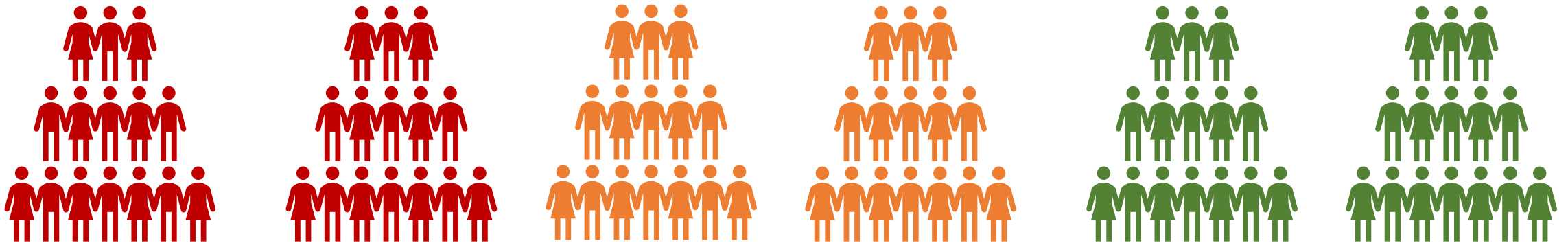
- Each wave includes **experimental modules** that are administered at the end of the core interview.



The Health and Retirement Study

- Each wave includes **experimental modules** that are administered at the end of the core interview.
- In the 2020 wave, one of these experimental modules included a measure of procrastination

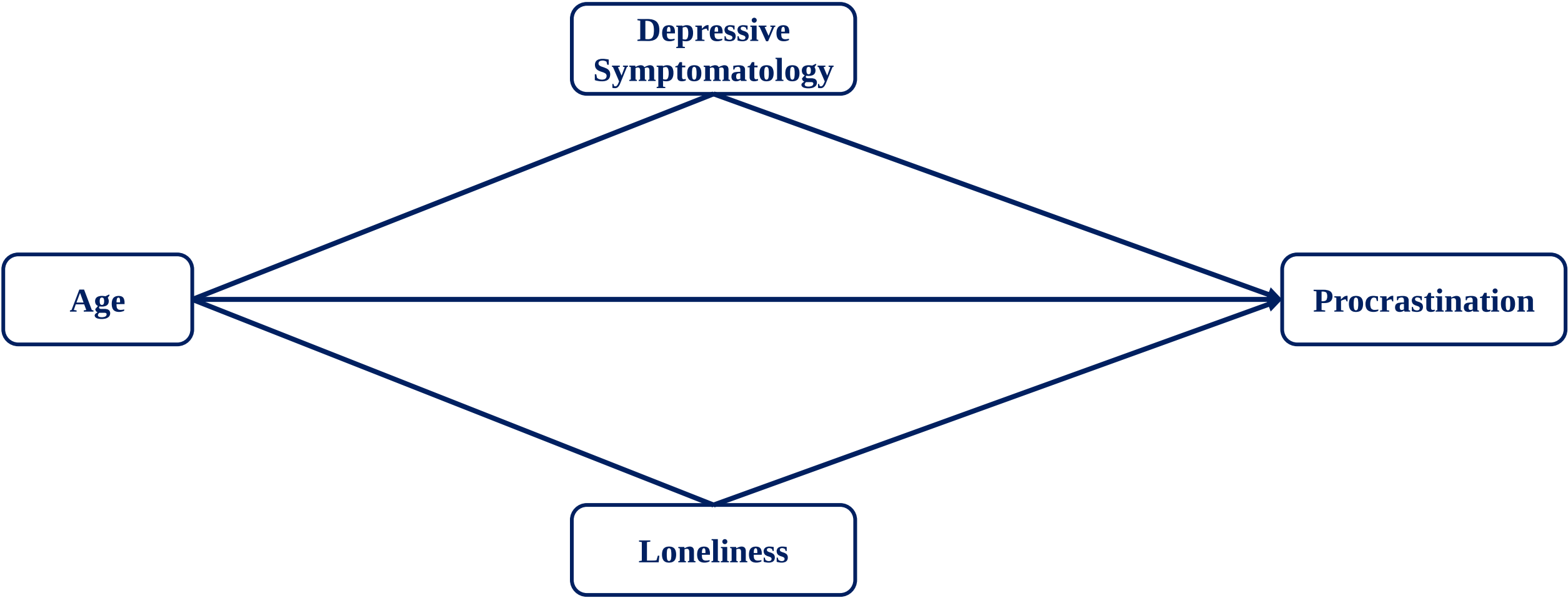
N = 1320

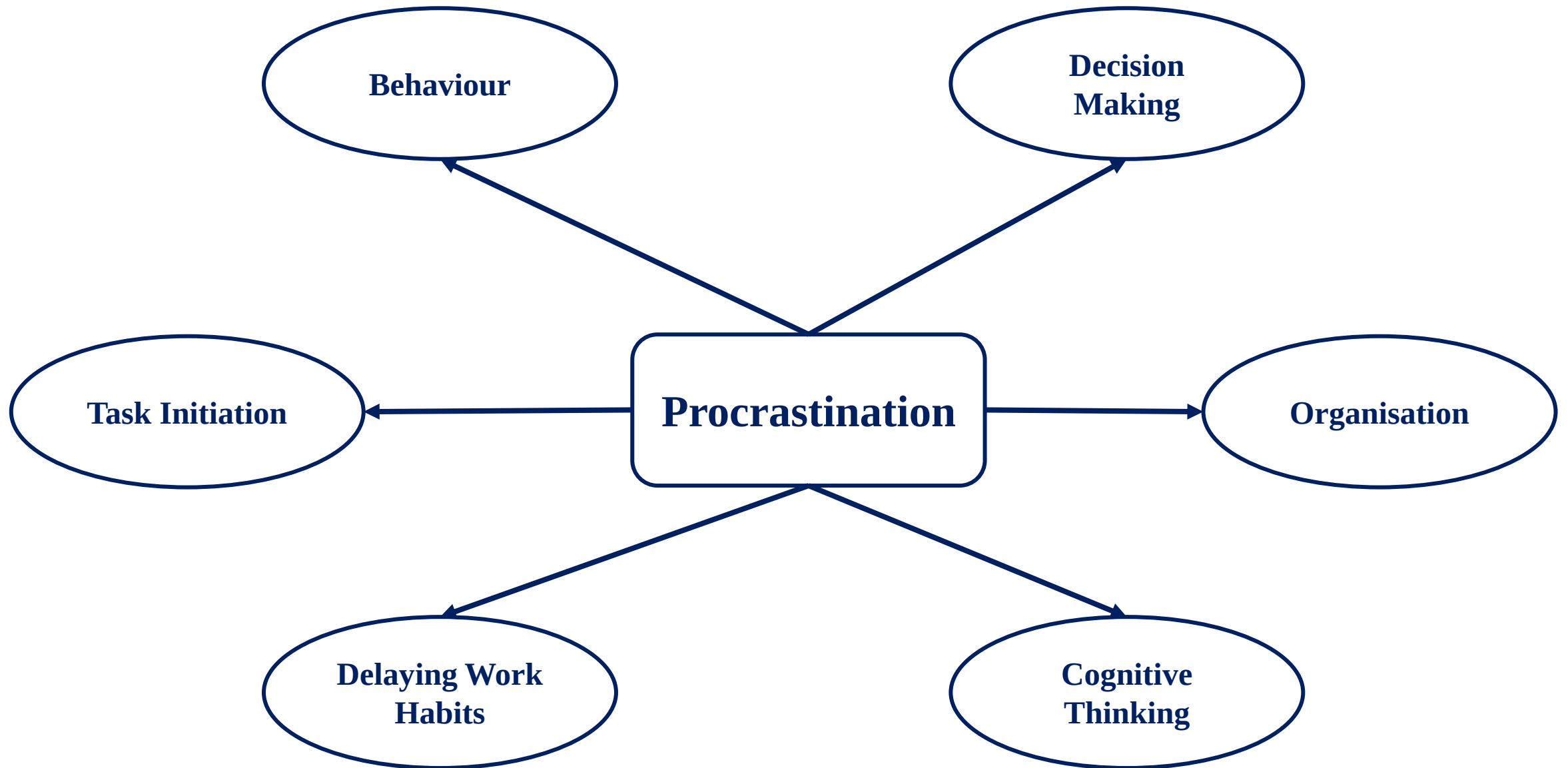


Age

Procrastination







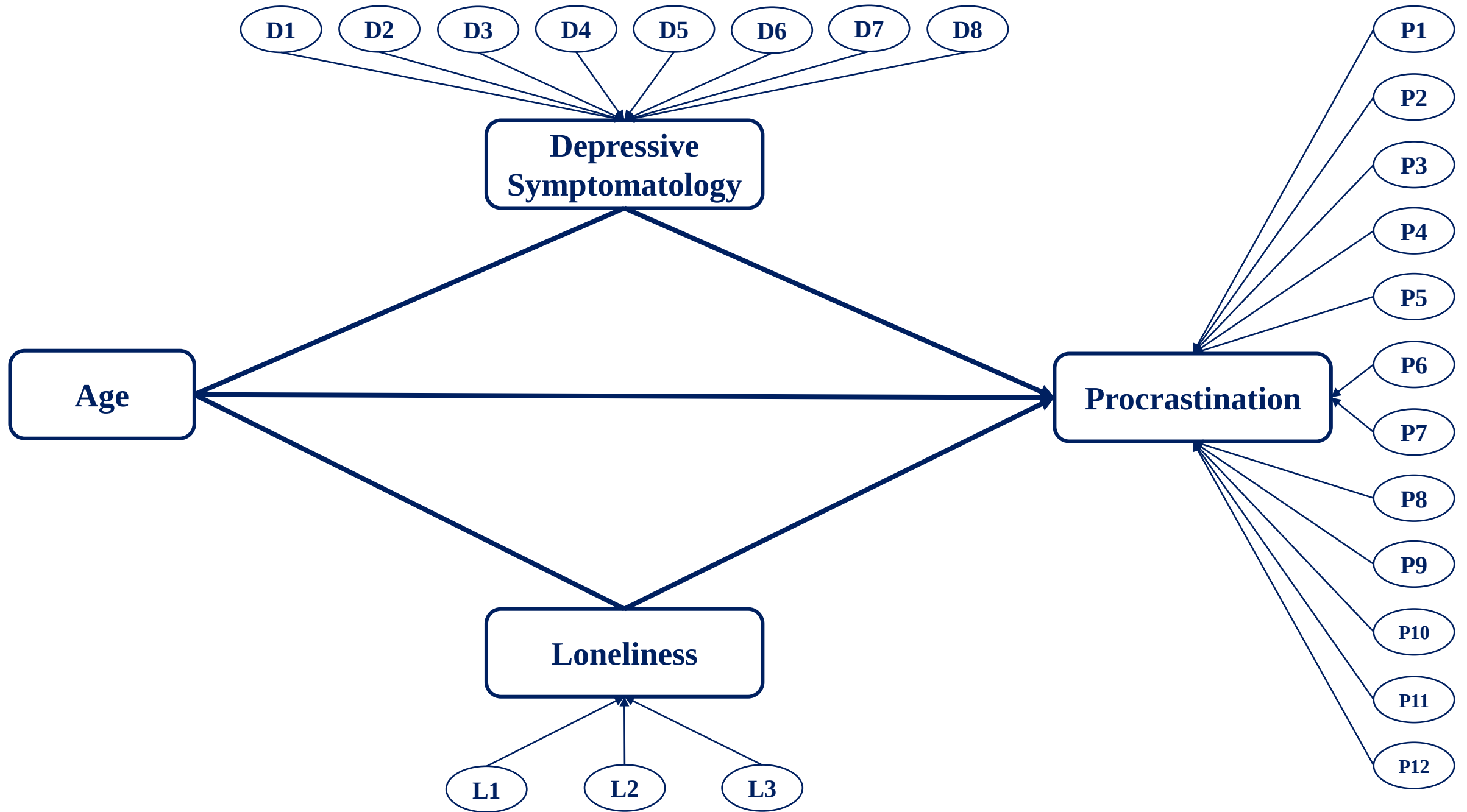
Pure Procrastination Scale

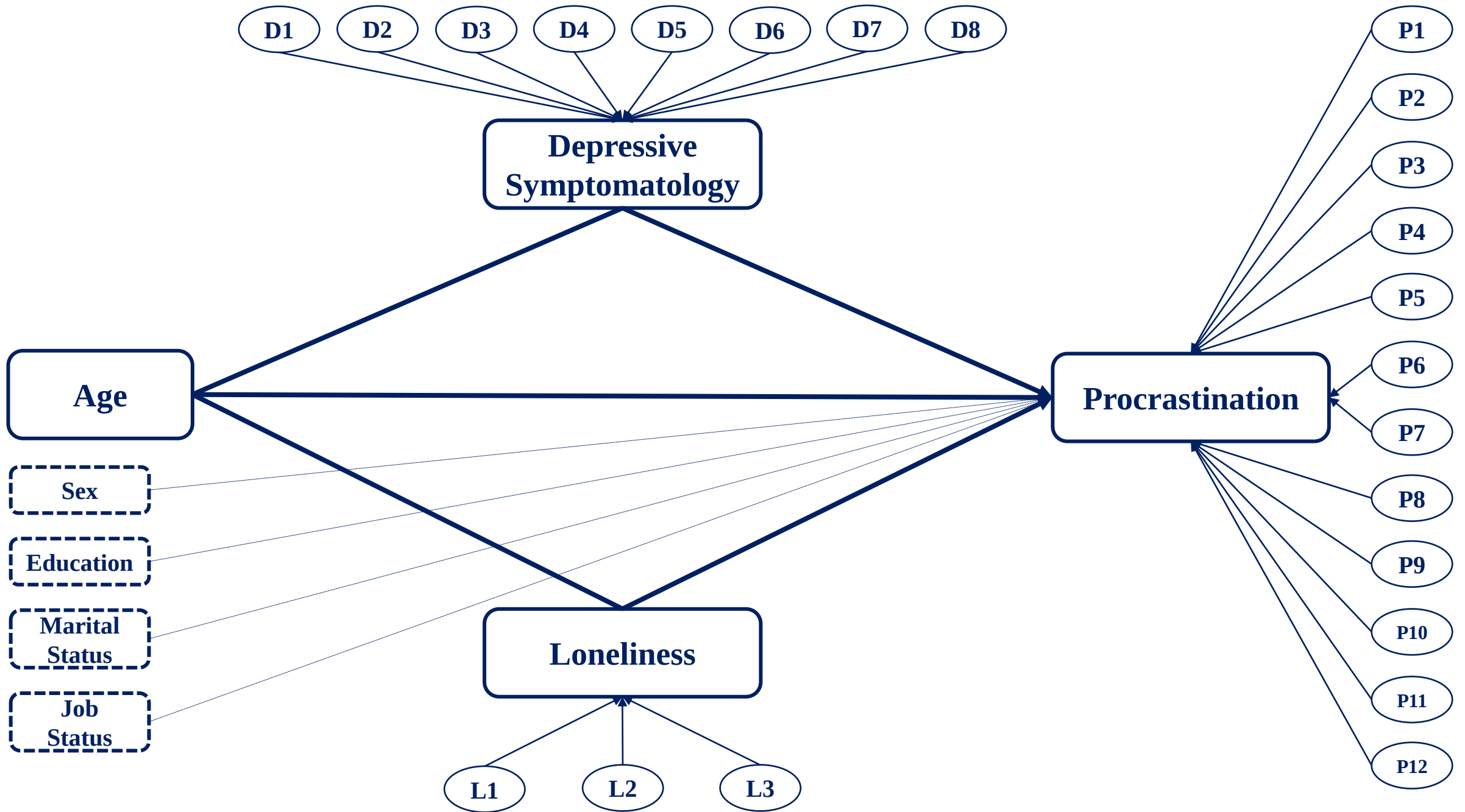
Please write a number next to each statement to indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with that statement.

Strongly Disagree	Disagree	Somewhat Disagree	Neither Agree Nor Disagree	Somewhat Agree	Agree	Strongly Agree
1	2	3	4	5	6	7

- ___ 1. I delay making decisions until it's too late.
- ___ 2. Even after I make a decision I delay acting upon it.
- ___ 3. I waste a lot of time on trivial matters before getting to the final decisions.
- ___ 4. In preparation for some deadlines, I often waste time by doing other things.
- ___ 5. Even jobs that require little else except sitting down and doing them, I find that they seldom get done for days.
- ___ 6. I often find myself performing tasks that I had intended to do days before.
- ___ 7. I am continually saying "I'll do it tomorrow."
- ___ 8. I generally delay before starting on work I have to do.
- ___ 9. I find myself running out of time.
- ___ 10. I don't get things done on time.
- ___ 11. I am not very good at meeting deadlines.
- ___ 12. Putting things off till the last minute has cost me money in the past.

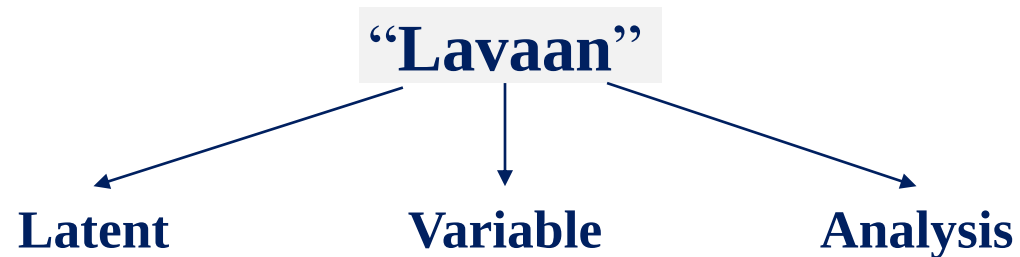
Procrastination





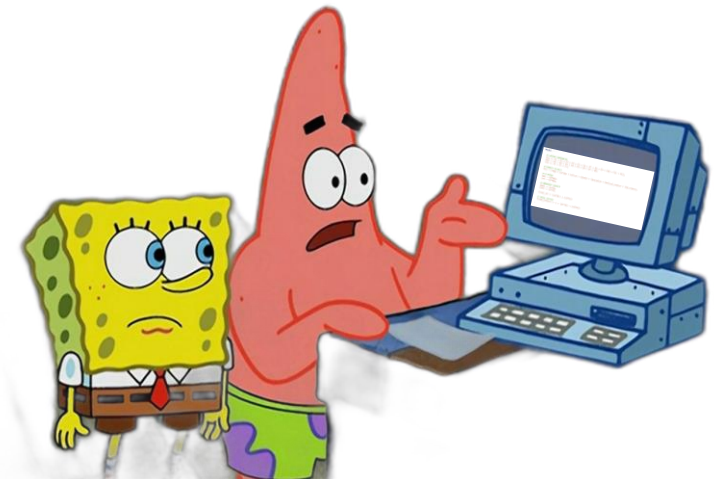
Structural Equation Modelling

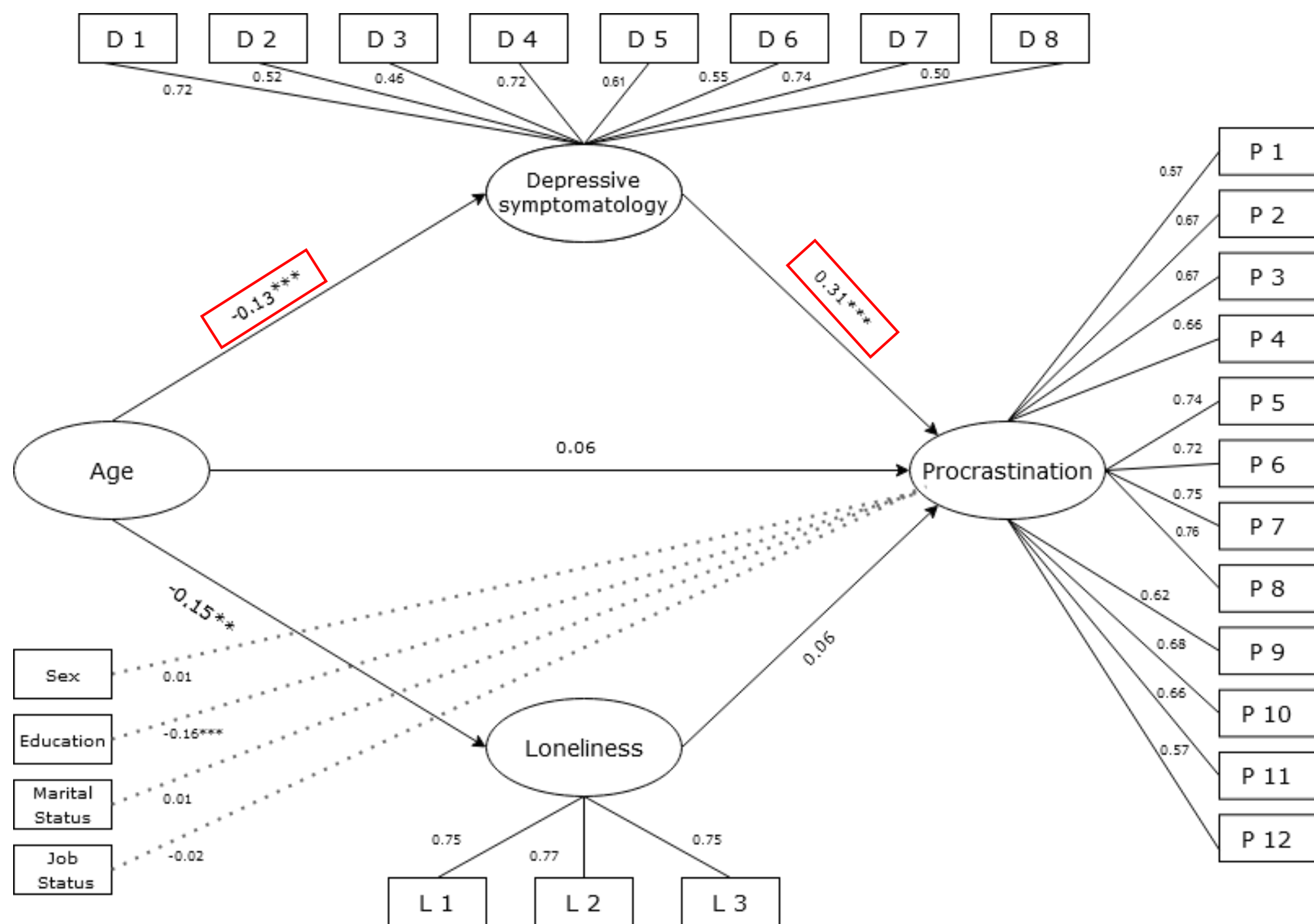
- SEM allows us to explain relationships between measured variables and latent variables, and relationships between latent variables themselves
- Also provides estimations of direct and indirect effects between variables



Structural Equation Modelling

```
Model <- '  
  
# LATENT VARIABLES  
Pro =~ P1 + P2 + P3 + P4 + P5 + P6 + P7 + P8 + P9 + P10 + P11 + P12;  
Dep =~ D1 + D2 + D3 + D4 + D5 + D6 + D7 + D8;  
Lon =~ L1 + L2 + L3;  
  
# DIRECT EFFECT  
Pro ~ c*Age + b1*dep + b2*Lon + Gender + Education + Marital_status + Job_status;  
  
# A PATHS  
Dep ~ a1*Age;  
Lon ~ a2*Age;  
  
# INDIRECT EFFECT  
DIDE := a1*b1;  
LIDE := a2*b2;  
  
Total_IE := (a1*b1) + (a2*b2)  
  
# TOTAL EFFECT  
Total_Effect := c + (a1*b1) + (a2*b2)  
'
```

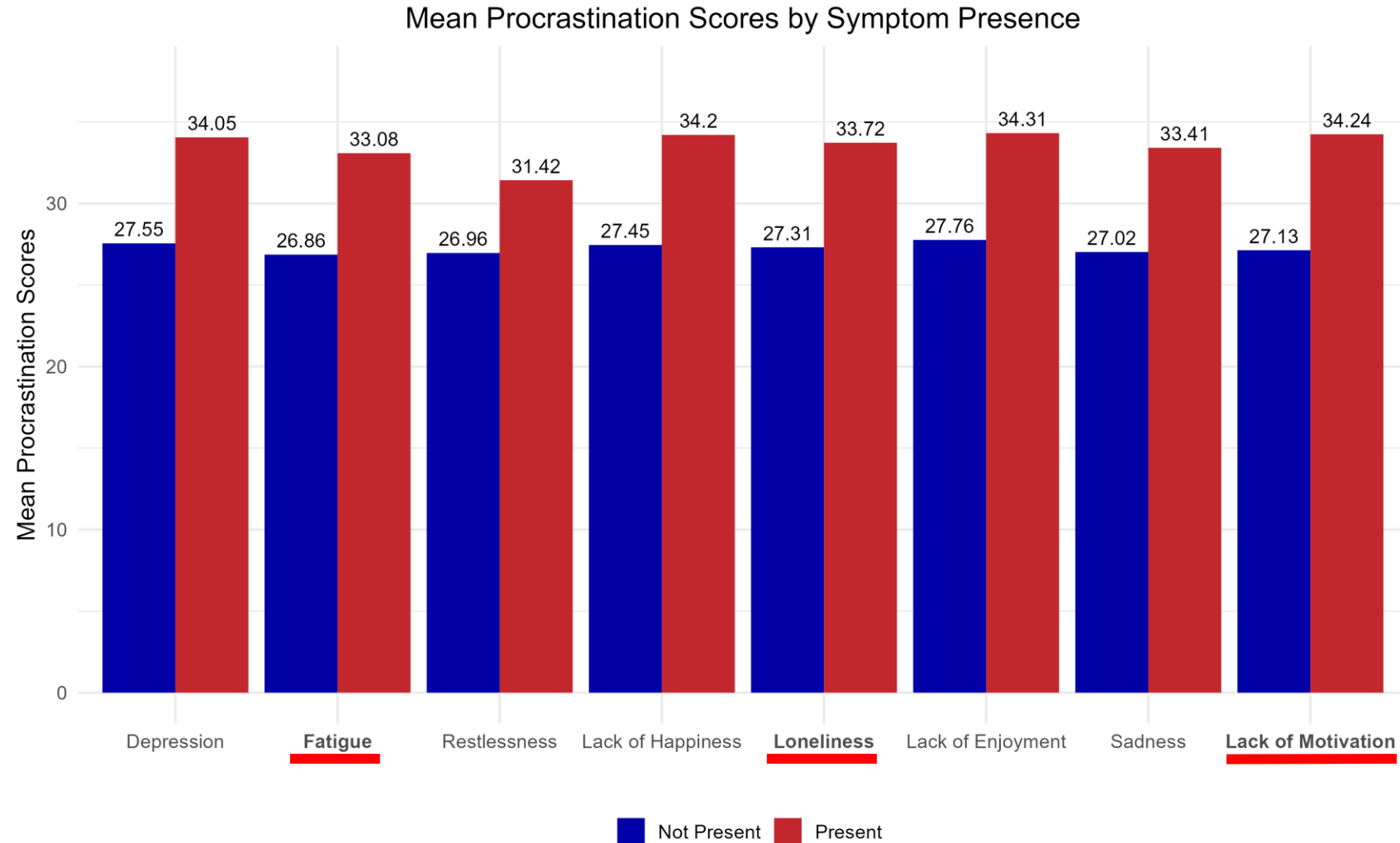




Procrastination – Depression

- While age may not directly influence procrastination, the presence of depressive symptoms among older adults can contribute to variations in procrastinatory behaviours.
- Older adults are less likely to experience cognitive-affective symptoms and more likely to experience fatigue, sleep disturbances, reduced interest in activities and concentration, and cognitive decline (Fiske et al., 2009)
- These depressive symptoms can inadvertently hinder one's ability to initiate and complete tasks

Procrastination – Depression



Procrastination - Conclusions

- Procrastination is a complex behaviour that can have detrimental effects for older adults.
- Consequently, older adults who experience multiple depressive symptoms may be particularly susceptible to procrastination
- Currently, the existing body of literature on procrastination in older adults remains relatively limited.

References

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QUESTIONS

